

Festivals: Text A

Read the text and complete the table.

The Snake Festival

Every year on the first Thursday in May the small town of Cocullo in Italy sees thousands of visitors. They are all arriving to see the annual Snake Festival. The festival is held on Saint Dominic's Day. St Dominic lived in the town in the 11th century. At that time there were many snakes in the town and many people died of snakebites. Saint Dominic got rid of the snakes and the people of Cocullo hold this festival every year to remember him. For some weeks before the festival, people collect snakes and then, on St Dominic's Day, they put all the snakes on a statue of St Dominic. At midday they carry the statue and the snakes in a procession through the town. At the front of the procession is a band playing music and at the back are women in costume who give sweets and bread shaped like snakes to the people who are watching. At the end of the procession there are fireworks.

	Snake Festival	Land Diving Festival	Bun Festival	May Day
Where?				
When?				
Why?				
What happens?				
Special Food?				

Festivals: Text B

Read the text and complete the table.

The Land Diving Festival

Pentecost Island in Vanuatu is famous for the Land Diving Festival, which takes place every Saturday in May. This festival celebrates the harvest, but there is an old story which says that it began when a woman had an argument with her husband and ran off into the forest. He followed her and she climbed a tree to get away. He climbed the tree after her and she jumped down. He jumped after her and was injured. She was unhurt because she had tied a vine to her ankle which stopped her hitting the ground. Now the men of the island hold this festival every year. They build a wooden tower, 20 to 30 metres high. They climb the tower and tie vines to their ankles. Then they jump off the tower. The people below sing and dance to encourage them. The islanders believe that the higher you jump, the better the harvest will be. In the 1980's the New Zealander AJ Hackett developed the modern sport of bungee jumping, based on this festival.

	Snake Festival	Land Diving Festival	Bun Festival	May Day
Where?				
When?				
Why?				
What happens?				
Special Food?				

Festivals: Text C

Read the text and complete the table.

The Hong Kong Bun Festival

This festival is held on the island of Cheung Chau in Hong Kong in early May every year, around the time of Buddha's birthday. The festival celebrates the god Pak Tai, who drove pirates and illness away from the island. In the festival, the islanders pray for safety from pirates and illness. The festival lasts for seven days. For three of those days everyone on the island is vegetarian. There is a procession through the village with lion dances, dragon dances and musicians. In the procession children in colourful costumes are carried high above people's heads. The islanders make three 20-metre-high bamboo towers and cover these with buns. At midnight on the last day people light fires and then climb the towers to get the buns. They wear bags on their backs to collect the buns and when they come down from the towers, they give them to everyone who is watching. Then everyone celebrates with fireworks.

	Snake Festival	Land Diving Festival	Bun Festival	May Day
Where?				
When?				
Why?				
What happens?				
Special Food?				

Festivals: Text D

Read the text and complete the table.

May Day

The first of May is called May Day in the UK. This is a very old festival held to celebrate the first day of summer. Many towns and villages still hold traditional May Day celebrations. Some towns and villages decorate the streets and houses with flowers. In others, there is dancing and the people put up a Maypole. This is a tall pole with coloured ribbons hanging from the top. The dancers take a ribbon each and dance around the pole. As they dance, the ribbons make a colourful pattern around the Maypole. It is also traditional to choose a May Queen and crown her. She wears a white dress and a crown of flowers and walks at the front of a procession through the streets. In Padstow, a village in the south-west, two men dress up as horses and everyone follows them through the streets singing an old song. In another village there is a 'Cheese Rolling' competition. Everyone goes to the top of a very steep hill. A big round cheese is rolled down the hill and everyone tries to chase it. The winner gets free cheese for twenty years!

	Snake Festival	Land Diving Festival	Bun Festival	May Day
Where?				
When?				
Why?				
What happens?				
Special Food?				

Festivals around the world

Topic

Festivals

Learning outcomes

- Learn and practise vocabulary for describing festivals
- Read and understand important information from a short text about a festival
- Collaborate with others to present information about an invented festival

Age and level

13-17, Adults (B1+)

Time

50-60 minutes

Materials

- Texts A, B, C, D
- (Optional) Images of the following festivals (for example):
 - Snake Festival in Cocullo, Italy: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-europe-48132701>
 - Land diving in Vanuatu: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Land_diving
 - Cheung Chau Bun Festival: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cheung_Chau_Bun_Festival
 - May Day in the UK: <https://www.maypoledancing.co.uk/>

Introduction

This is an integrated skills lesson, in which students will discuss festivals. First, they will create a mind map of vocabulary used to describe festivals. They will then work in small groups to read different texts describing the reasons behind and the customs practised in four festivals from different parts of the

world. They will then share the information about their festival and discuss which one they would like to attend and why. Finally, they will work together to invent and describe an imaginary festival to celebrate a calendar event such as the middle of winter, the first day of autumn, etc.

Procedure

1. Lead-in (5 mins)	- Put students into groups of 3 / 4. Ask them to discuss the questions: What is your favourite festival? How does your family celebrate it? - Collect feedback from a few groups if you like, but it's not necessary. The aim of this activity is to get students thinking about the topic of the lesson and vocabulary related to festivals.
2. Vocabulary brainstorm (10 mins)	- Write the word 'festivals' in the middle of the board and create a mind map to record vocabulary related to the topic of festivals. You can find out about mind maps here: https://www.teachingenglish.org.uk/professional-development/teachers/knowning-subject/d-h/mind-map - Ask students to suggest or introduce words related to different categories, as in the example below. As a minimum, introduce the words which appear in the texts: - What: (festival, celebration plus collocations: hold a festival, celebrate something) - What happens: (procession, fireworks, music, musicians, band dance, dancers, decorate, wear costumes) - Food: (sweets)
3. Preparation for reading texts (5-10 mins)	- Explain that students are going to read about four different festivals. Give the names of each festival: Snake Festival, Bun Festival, Land Diving Festival, May Day. If possible, show some pictures of festivals. You can search for suitable images of the festivals before the lesson. - Ask students to guess where and why each festival takes place, and to guess what happens at each festival. Note: If students are already familiar with one or more of the festivals, you could omit the text. Alternatively, you could write a similar simple text about other festivals which are new to your students.

As an alternative, you could give students the framework provided with the texts and ask them to research an unfamiliar festival and complete the framework with what they find out. They can then form small groups and share information about the festivals (instead of completing the jigsaw reading).

**4. Jigsaw reading
(15 mins)**

- Divide the class into 4 groups: A, B, C, D. Give Text A to each student in Group A; give Text B to each student in Group B etc.
- In their groups, students read the texts together. They can help each other with any unfamiliar vocabulary and use dictionaries where necessary. You can also walk around and help.
- Each student completes the framework below the text.
- When the frameworks are completed, put students into new groups. Each group should contain a student from Group A, Group B, Group C and Group D.
- In their new groups, students share information about the festivals. They add information about all the festivals to the framework.
- If necessary, check answers with the class, or display the completed framework for students to check. The completed framework is available at the end of this lesson plan.
- Ask students to discuss which festival they would like to see most and why.

**5. Follow-up task
(15-20 mins)**

- Tell students to remain in the same groups of 4.
- Explain that each group should work together and invent a festival for one of the following events (or another special calendar event):
 - Midwinter
 - The first day of autumn (or any other season)
 - The longest / shortest day
 - A special harvest
- Groups use the same framework as before to structure their discussions:

Where?	
When?	
Why?	
What happens?	
Special food?	

- When the table is completed, groups can present their invented festivals. They can use their tables to give an oral presentation, or they could make posters / PowerPoint / online presentations. Alternatively, they could write short descriptions for display around the classroom or online.
- Students listen to / read about each other's festivals and say which they would like to attend and why.

Contributed by

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Answer key:

	Snake Festival	Land Diving Festival	Bun Festival	May Day
Where?	Cocullo, Italy	Pentecost Island, Vanuatu	Cheung Chau, Hong Kong	UK
When?	First Thursday in May (St Dominic's Day)	Every Saturday in May	Early May, around the time of Buddha's birthday	First of May
Why?	St Dominic lived in the village in 11 th century. Many people died of snakebites. He got rid of the snakes.	Celebrates harvest. Also story of a woman who jumped from a tree with a vine around her ankle.	Celebrates Pak Tai, who drove pirates and illness away from the island.	Celebrates first day of summer
What happens?	People put snakes on statue of St Dominic. They carry the statue through the town. There is music and fireworks.	Men build a wooden tower – 20-30m high. They jump off with vines around their ankles. People sing and dance below.	People pray for safety from pirates and illness. Procession with music and dances. Children are carried. People make 3 30m towers covered in buns. On last day, people climb towers to get buns. Fireworks.	Decorate streets and houses with flowers. Dancing around a tall pole. Choose a May Queen. In one village, two men dress as horses and sing. In another, people roll a big cheese down a hill.
Special Food?	Sweets and bread shaped like snakes.	(Doesn't say)	People are vegetarian for 3 days. People give away buns on the last day.	Cheese in one village.